EVOLUTION, 1965–71

After the 1965 war, the Indian Army resumed its modernization programme. A second airborne brigade, 51 (Independent) Parachute Brigade, was established in late 1965. As Southern Command had no divisional headquarters in 1965 and had been forced to improvise, 11 Mountain Division became an infantry division and moved to Ahmedabad to cover the Gujarat sector. In November 1966, Advance Headquarters Delhi and Rajasthan Area was redesignated 12 Infantry Division. Besides these two formations, 36, 39 and 54 Infantry divisions were raised in 1966, while 57 Mountain Division was also raised. Three new independent armoured brigades – 14 (formed in 1967), 16 (1969) and 2 (1970) – were established, bringing the Indian Army's total assets to 14 infantry divisions (3, 7, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 19, 23, 25, 26, 39 and 54), nine mountain divisions (2, 4, 5, 6, 8, 17, 20, 27 and 57), one armoured division (1), four armoured brigades (2, 3, 14 and 16) and two parachute brigades (50 and 51). On 7 October 1971, HQ II Corps was established at Krishna Nagar; its first GOC was Lieutenant General Tapishwar Narain Raina. An ad hoc headquarters, Foxtrot Sector, was formed at Fazilka in 1971, shortly before the Bangladesh War began.

India decided in the early 1960s to pursue the indigenous production of a main battle tank. The prototype of the 105mm-armed Vijayanta, based on the British Vickers Mk 1, was ready by 1963 and entered service in December 1965. Though a second armoured division was not formed after the 1965 war, the armoured corps did see the introduction of new Soviet armour – the T-54 and T-55 main battle tanks and the PT-76 amphibious tank – and the raising of ten new armoured regiments (64–73) by late 1971. In 1968, the Indian Army formed its first anti-tank guided missile unit with the raising of 70 Guided Missile Regiment, equipped with SS.11B1 missiles initially procured from France and produced domestically from 1970.